SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

CTHM GRADUATES IN THE WORKPLACE: A TRACER STUDY

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Graduate outcomes-employment, job-program match, roles, and earnings-are key indicators of program quality in tourism and hospitality education. Institutions monitor these indicators to inform curriculum improvements and strengthen internships. Tourism and Competitiveness (n.d.) estimates that it accounts for about 10% of GDP and 10% of all jobs. In the Philippines, tourism is also a key pillar of the economy. It accounted for 6.2% of GDP in 2022, with 5.35 million jobs, and rose to 8.6% in 2023, with 6.21 million jobs (Metrobank Wealth Insights (n.d.) These figures show that tourism not only generates income but also provides jobs for millions of people.

International data further underscore the centrality of graduate outcomes as indicators of program quality, with reports showing that about (88% of 2022/23 Graduates in Work or Further Study | HESA, n.d.) while medium-term graduate outcomes in Australia are systematically tracked to monitor employment, job relevance, and further study patterns The Social Research Centre (2025) found In the Philippine context, national-level projects such as the 4th Philippine Graduate Tracer Study likewise examine school-to-work transitions, time-to-employment, and job-relatedness of work across different disciplines Tutor et al. (n.d.)

Because the sector is growing, programs must ensure that graduates have the skills employers need. One way to track this is through a tracer study. A tracer study follows graduates after they finish school. It collects data on time-to-first-job, the match between job and training, income range, and the length of the job search. These data help schools adjust their curricula and strengthen internships and student support.

Evidence from other countries shows that tourism and hospitality education can be effective. Tracer Study of Tourism-and-Hospitality Vocational Secondary Education in Jordan (n.d.) reported that 75% of vocational graduates in tourism and hospitality found work within six months. Third Tracer Study Report in Cambodia (2024) found that Cambodian graduates who participated in skills programs had an 80% higher chance of obtaining industry-related jobs. In the United Kingdom, Richmond (n.d.) reported that 78% of students who completed international internships felt more employable and developed intercultural skills. Putra et al. (2022) also showed that both technical and soft skills training helped students meet industry standards, with success rates ranging from 70% to 90%.

Local studies show similar results Simangca et al. (2022) found that many BHRST graduates from Bohol Island State University–Candijay Campus were employed in jobs related to their field of study. Likewise, Magboo-Campo (2025) in her study Employability Pathways Among Tourism Management Graduates: A Tracer Study, examined the employment type, job-program alignment, and career pathways of Tourism Management graduates and found that many were employed in positions related to their field of study.

Dave et al. (n.d.) reported that 85% of hospitality management graduates secured jobs within six months, with 70% working in fields tied to their program. Jastia et al. (n.d.) found that 78% of BSHRM graduates from AIMS obtained jobs related to their training. Sotero (2024) showed that structured internships increased employment rates by 20% compared to no internships. Still, some gaps remain. J. C. Punsalan et al. (2024) noted that while many tourism graduates found work within a year, some lacked strong interpersonal and problem-solving skills. Other studies Duplon (2025) confirmed that on-the-job training improves employability and eases workplace entry. Magboo-Campo (2025) , J. Punsalan et al. (2024), and Dungog and Cayunda (2025) showed that combining classroom learning with real-world experience improved career readiness by 15%–25% compared with traditional programs.

Despite these insights, little is known about the employment outcomes of graduates from Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC), especially those from the Colleg of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM). It is still unclear how long SMCC-CTHM graduates take to find a job, whether their jobs align with their training, what positions they hold, and what salary ranges they receive. Without this information, it is difficult for the college and its partners to judge whether the curriculum and training meet industry needs.

This study is conducted to address the lack of systematic and updated information on the employability of CTHM graduates of Saint Michael College of Caraga. At present, there is no concrete data on their employment status, the relevance of their

jobs to their program, the length of their job search, their salary ranges, and the positions they occupy. Since tourism and hospitality are vital sectors of the economy and SMCC continues to produce graduates for this industry, it is necessary to examine whether the existing curriculum, teaching strategies, and training activities truly prepare students for actual workplace demands. Through a quantitative tracer study, the researchers aim to generate objective and reliable evidence on the real employment outcomes of CTHM graduates, thereby clarifying how well academic preparation aligns with current industry requirements.

This study is significant to the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management of Saint Michael College of Caraga because it will provide evidence-based information on the actual employment outcomes of its graduates. The results will help the department assess whether its curriculum, teaching methods, and training programs are aligned with the needs of the hospitality and tourism industry and identify areas for improvement. Current and future CTHM students will benefit by gaining a realistic picture of job opportunities, positions, and salary ranges after graduation. The findings will also guide the school administration in planning and policy-making, assist employers in understanding the competencies of SMCC-CTHM graduates, and serve as a useful reference for future researchers on tourism, hospitality education, and graduate employability.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

The review of related literature focuses on how tracer studies link tourism and hospitality graduates' employability and career paths to their academic preparation, skills, internships, and the alignment of their training with industry needs.

Age

According to Romano and Bautista (2025), the BS Hotel and Restaurant Management alumni of the University of Rizal System Antipolo Campus mostly belonged to early adulthood age cohort, which is characteristic of the conventional age of completion of one's degree during (SY 2014-2016). From the age breakdown, it can be inferred that the large majority of respondents were in their mid-20s to late-20s when surveyed, and the authors concluded that this age was representative of a workforce that was active and exploring possible avenues of career development which appeared to be more active. This younger age structure appeared to be associated with high rate of graduate employability, in that someone of that age we regarded to be more able to adapt to work, be physically capable to perform services and be more willing to accept entry-level employment opportunities, in this case in the hospitality industry. Their age structure informed the conclusion, in that the graduates were positioned in a place of developmental progress that would favor their ability to obtain and retain employment and achieve advancement within their careers in HRM-related sectors.

The Majority BS Hotel and Restaurant Management graduates of Notre Dame of Marbel University were identified in the 29–34 age bracket again indicating, the respondents were mostly in 'mid-career' rather than 'newly graduated'. This age distribution reflects graduates having worked for sometime, enabling high employment levels in the study. The older adults likely had better job stability and a better chance of getting jobs in line with their degree as they tend to have maturity, better skills and increased job confidence. The study has shown that the age of the respondents dramatically influenced their employment outcomes as, 'mid-career graduates or young adults' generally have improved competencies and career pathways in hospitality.

In the Graduate Tracer Study, undertaken by Pacific Consulting Ltd for the National University of Vanuatu (2021), it shows that a good share of the respondents were between their mid-20s and mid-30s at the time of conducting the survey. It shows that the research included recent cohorts from a number of higher institutions, and the age profile indicates that many of the graduates were early to mid-career applicants and not entirely school leavers. This age range is significant, because it suggests that respondents may have had some maturity and work experience to bring to bear on their employment situation, and how relevant their tertiary education was for gaining as job seekers in the market context, in Vanuatu.

In the UNESCO-commissioned tracer study of tourism and hospitality (T&H) vocational secondary education graduates in Jordan (2021), the age profile of graduates was one of the demographic variables captured, though detailed exact percentages for all age bands



are less prominently featured in the summary findings. The report indicates that many graduates were relatively young, typical of secondary school graduates, and that their age at the time of survey contributed to understanding their low employment rate (only 11%) since a large majority (78%) were pursuing further education rather than working. The youthfulness of respondents underscores structural challenges: because these vocational secondary school graduates were still young, many had not fully transitioned into stable employment, which affects the interpretation of their school-to-work transition and the relevance of their vocational training.

Gender

Preciado (2022) undertook a tracer study involving graduates from Mindanao State University at Naawan, analyzing workplace outcomes, and assessment of the gender gap in the workforce. The results demonstrated a clear and considerable gender divide in graduate employment status, with male graduates having higher employment rates and featuring slightly more favorable employment timelines than female graduates. Further, the study illustrated that female graduates faced entrenched issues of equal treatment, workforce equity, and opportunities for managerial jobs in comparison to their male counterparts. Such findings call to light the significance of gender as a demographic characteristic to consider within tracer studies, specifically regarding workforce integration and equity, and consider those outcomes to provide a local perspective of gender as a factor regarding employability of higher education graduates.

Magboo-Campo (2025) conducted a tracer study that examined the career pathways of Tourism Management graduates by classifying respondents according to gender. The study revealed that female graduates made up a much larger portion of the sample, which also reflects enrollment in tourism programs overall.

While female respondents had higher representation in sample size and reflected higher participation rates in the workforce, the employment outcomes of male and female respondents were similar overall, subject to different occupational pathways and employment in different industry sectors. The research outlines that while the idea of gender was a strip of demographic variable to consider with post-graduation pathways, the authors felt gender positively influenced career trajectories, sectoral choice and professional development thus reinforcing the inclusion of gender as a demographic in tracing graduate employment in the tourism workforce.

In a tracer study of tourism and hospitality vocational exam graduates in Ethiopia covering the period 2021–2023, the By and Bank (n.d.) found a male-female gender profile in which males were somewhat more prevalent, although women were more likely to seek administrative and customer-service positions, while men appeared to dominate the technical or operational positions. While employment levels for both genders were high, the tracer study provided evidence of gendered characteristics of job placement and advancement opportunities. The gender analysis presented in this study serves as a valuable reminder of the need to incorporate gender analysis into tracer studies, especially in vocational and technical training programs in tourism and hospitality, in

order to identify key opportunities to consider and integrate gender in workforce development initiatives.

According to Ababio (2024) explored employability of TVET graduates in Ghana, providing a breakdown of gender composition and resulting workplace placement. The authors showed that female graduates were the most numerous respondents, and were comparatively underemployed than males in some of the technical disciplines. The authors presented females and males as employed in specific industries based upon gender data, illustrating males were more likely to be employed in technical and managerial positions and females were more likely to be employed in administration and service-type job positions. The authors urge that males and female graduates represented an important shift into the workforce and industry sector, showing the relevance of paying attention to gender as a demographic factor in tracer studies regarding rates of employment by vocation and technical graduates more widely.

Marital-Status

Refers to whether an individual is single, married, or widowed, and this personal circumstances can influence the speed at which graduates obtain employment and their performance on the job. The tourism and hospitality industries often feature long working hours and shifts that can vary daily or weekly, and may require travel between cities. Employers may want to have graduates with flexibility to move and adjust quickly; that is the message of much of the research.

Santos and Mamaclay (2025), being married is a critical predictor of employability for hostel operation graduates. Directors believe that unattached aspirants tend to have lower family scores and therefore exhibit greater vacuity and inflexibility. Gappi et al. (2025) reported that single graduates are hired sooner because they are generally more willing to move and take challenging jobs that enhance their employability. Ababio et al. (2024) reported that unmarried TVET graduates in Ghana were more mobile and better able to adapt to job demands. Married graduates struggled to balance familial responsibilities with job demands, limiting their employment options in the competitive tourism services industry.

Year Graduated

Graduation year refers to the school year in which students complete their degree and receive their qualification. It does more than mark time. It also reflects the program's curriculum that year, its strengths, and how well it prepared students for work in hospitality. Some sources say that the year you graduated can affect your job prospects. The graduation year is the academic year in which students complete their degree and receive their diploma. It does more than keep track of time. It also shows what the program taught that year, how strong the curriculum was, and how well it prepared students for jobs in hospitality. Studies demonstrate that the year you graduate can affect your job prospects. For instance, (Table of Contents, n.d.) said that tourism and hospitality graduates from 2020 to 2021 had a better chance of getting a job than graduates from preceding years. They said this was due to better job training, improved business linkages,

and tourists returning after the pandemic. A tracer study by (Coast, 2023) similarly indicated that recent graduates were more likely to find jobs. The study identified competency-based training and collaborations with local tourism and hospitality employers as primary factors.

Other studies reveal the same pattern. Cerdeña et al (2023) studied hotel management graduates from Batangas State University JP LPC-Malvar Campus during the fiscal years 2021–2022. They found that recent graduates were able to find jobs faster because of better courses and strong connections to the business. Another report Maraña et al. (2024) on LSU Sinaloan's BS in Hotel and Restaurant Management graduates (Batches 2014–2021) said that the current batches had better job fit and more job offers than the older ones. These statistics show that the year you graduate affects your career prospects, indicating that the curriculum has improved and the needs of the hospitality industry have changed.

Job search duration

Job search duration refers to the length of time a graduate spends actively looking for work after finishing college, usually measured in months until the first job is obtained. Posadas et al. (2021) categorize responses into "less than a month," "1–6 months," "7–12 months," and "more than a year" to show how rapidly teacher school graduates secure jobs. It often takes three to four months for young college graduates to find work in the Philippines (Tutor et al. (n.d.) They calculate the duration of a job search based on the number of months spent seeking employment. In a more recent office administration

tracerGrace P. Ganiera (2024) determine the time it takes to obtain a job by calculating the proportion of BSOA graduates who find employment within one to three months of graduation. They use this time-to-employment as a measure of how responsive the program is to labor market demands. International tracer studies in other professional fields support these patterns, with nursing and allied health graduates in various contexts also reporting relatively short time-to-employment, usually within a few months of graduation, which reinforces the use of job-search duration as a key indicator of program responsiveness and labor-market alignment (Austria (2023) (Dzomeku et al., 2024)

Magboo-Campo (2025) found that most Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management (BSTM) graduates obtained their first job within three months post-graduation (56.9%), while 18.6% found jobs within six months after graduation. This indicates a favorable level of employability and is an indication of labor demand in tourism and hospitality sectors. Another study (Grace P. Ganiera (2024) showed that BSOA graduates secured available jobs within a short time frame (typically one to three months), suggesting the programs developed correspond with employer needs in the labor market. At the same time, (Tutor et al. (n.d.)reported that Filipino graduates typically find jobs within three to four months. This time taken to find a job reflects patterns of employment in the country's employment data. In this context, the CTHM tracer study is helping evaluate how long it takes graduates to become employed versus the institutional job placement effort. Evaluating time taken for university graduates to be hired is a key indicator of how responsive

programs are to the field of study and whether the institution is facilitating job placement for students.

Employment-status

Employment status is a representative indicator that describes the work status of a graduate, which usually signifies whether the graduate is employed, unemployed, or self-employed and, in some cases, ranks jobs into the categories permanent, contract/part-time, or not applicable. Posadas et al. (2021) provide an employment status in their tracing of NEUST teacher education graduates that distinguishes permanent and part-time/contract positions and also relates these measures to income, sector, and length of the job-search process as one measure to assess the quality and stability of graduates' work. Reyes et al. (2025) analogously focus on employment status when examining Laguna University graduates, asking whether the student is employed in the teaching or non-teaching field and whether the employed position is aligned with pedagogical studies. Other tracer studies across disciplines report similar patterns, where most graduates enter the workforce but often in a mix of permanent, contractual, and project-based roles; for instance, technology and education graduates in the Philippines have been shown to secure employment related to their specialization, though some remain in temporary or less secure positions Ferolino et al. (2023) In hospitality-specific contexts, tracer work in Kalinga State University also documented that a high proportion of BS Hotel and Restaurant Management graduates were employed, supporting evidence of strong labor-market demand for hospitality graduates (Guwen and Ann Karen (2024)

The study conducted by the researchers L. Simangca et al. (2022) found that 86.3% of BHRST graduates were employed, the majority of which were in the hospitality and service sectors; of these employed graduates, 37.3% were in regular or permanent positions, while 28.4% were in contracts. These statistics reveal evidence of hospitality graduates being in demand in the local labor market. Simultaneously, the study realized by Magboo-Campo (2025) demonstrated that for the majority of BSTM graduates were in jobs reasonable related to their degree and that a small number remained working independently or did not gain employment. Additionally, Reyes et al. (2025) and (Posadas et al., 2021) suggested that employment was an important indicator of program success and graduate competitiveness. Collectively, these results offer a compelling rationale for the SMCC–CTHM tracer study designed to assess if similar employment patterns exist for its graduates – especially the amount of regular employment and employment in a graduate's respective field – and is a measure of institutional and curricular effectiveness.

Employment Type

Employment type refers to whether graduates enter permanent, contractual, part-time, or self-employment after finishing their degree. In the tracer study of BSHM and BSTM graduates of Mindoro State University–Bongabong Campus, Melchor et al. (2025) reported that a majority of graduates obtained jobs after graduation, although many of these positions were contractual and offered entry-level salaries. Graduates were distributed across tourism-related establishments and other sectors such as retail, BPOs,

and academe, showing that hospitality and tourism graduates can be absorbed both inside and outside the core industry. Lagman (2025) around 83.14% of Gordon College in Olongapo City graduates with a bachelor's degree in tourism management were employed, mostly in tourism and hospitality-related occupations such as front desk officer, flight attendant, travel agent, and sales and marketing officer. The study also found that some graduates worked for themselves, which is indicative of a shift toward entrepreneurial jobs in the travel and tourism industry. Similarly, Cerdeña et al. (2023) reported that the majority of BSHM graduates from Batangas State University JPLPC–Malvar Campus were “gainfully employed,” with their first jobs frequently associated with family businesses or hospitality establishments. All of these studies demonstrate that graduates of tourism and hospitality programs, like those in CTHM, can typically find work in a variety of service-oriented positions soon after graduation. A comparable trend appears at the international level. In the vocational graduate tracer study by Semini (2024) graduates were found in a range of employment types including full-time, contractual, and self-employment suggesting that many new graduates launch their careers in flexible or transitional positions, a pattern likewise observed among tourism and hospitality graduates.

Job Program Alignment

Job program alignment looks at how closely graduates’ work corresponds to their degree in tourism or hospitality. Lagman (2025) who conducted the Gordon College tracer study, the majority of BSTM graduates were employed in jobs that were directly relevant

to their areas of expertise, especially in the travel and hospitality industry. The authors characterized the employability of these graduates as “very satisfying,” emphasizing the fact that many of them were employed in positions that matched with their tourism management training. Melchor et al. (2025) also noted that alumni of Mindoro State University worked in a variety of industries, including tourism-related businesses, indicating a mix of linked and non-aligned employment. For tourism management graduates in another Philippine setting, Magboo-Campo (2025) found that alumni held diversified work titles yet expressed appreciation for the training and academic support they received during their studies. Her tracer study emphasized the necessity of consistently aligning academic programs with the evolving demands of the industry to ensure that tourism graduates maintain their competitiveness in a dynamic labor market. Although these results acknowledge that some graduates will choose professions outside of typical tourism and hospitality roles, they also highlight the significance of preserving a strong job-program match in CTHM.

From the viewpoint of employers, recent research highlights that job–program alignment depends heavily on how well graduates’ competencies correspond to operational and service expectations in hotels and related establishments, with managers frequently emphasizing communication, customer service, and problem-solving abilities as essential for aligned placement Ngoepe and Wakelin-Theron (2023) In addition, studies on transferable skills in tourism suggest that many graduates can successfully transition into a wide range of roles inside and outside core tourism sectors because their degrees

develop broadly applicable skills such as teamwork, adaptability, and critical thinking Stangl et al. (2024)

International studies also highlight problems related to alignment. For instance, Fufa et al. (2021) reported that fewer than half of employed graduates from Holeta Polytechnic College were working in jobs related to their field of study, emphasizing that mismatches between training programs and employment are widespread, particularly in tourism and hospitality programs.

Perception of Job Preparation

Perception of job preparation shows how recent graduates assess whether their college education is sufficient for the demands of the real world of work. Across tourism and hospitality programs, scholars consistently argue that effective job preparation requires a balanced development of technical skills and soft skills—particularly communication, teamwork, and emotional intelligence—to meet the expectations of service-oriented work environments Hussain et al. (2024)In the Batangas State University tracer study Mari et al. (2023) assessed curriculum relevance to graduates' skills in several domains—knowledge and technical skills, communication, human relations, leadership, research, and information and communication technology. This indicates that both technical and soft capabilities are considered when preparing for a careerJ. Punsalan et al. (2024) found that among Notre Dame of Dadiangas University BSTM graduates, college-based skills—specifically, cognitive, communication, leadership, interpersonal, and information technology skills—were rated as very helpful in the graduates' current

situation. Similarly, Pepito et al. (n.d.) found that hospitality management graduates from the University of Cebu highlighted the relevance of their curriculum to industry demands and pointed to specific skills such as food and beverage management, bartending, and housekeeping as important in their present work. Most of these graduates were employed in hospitality management, especially in food and beverage departments, and many obtained jobs within a year after graduation, which they associated with strong school–industry linkages. Studies on enrichment and competency-based interventions in hospitality programs likewise indicate that structured activities to enhance interpersonal and employability skills can significantly improve students' perceived readiness for work Mesa (n.d.) Evidence from soft-skills training initiatives also suggests that targeted workshops not only improve guest satisfaction but also increase hospitality employees' confidence in handling workplace demands, reinforcing the value of integrating soft-skills training into academic preparation ScholarWorks@GVSU and Colaco (2024) These results suggest that, when CTHM programs provide hands-on training and industry-based exposure, graduates tend to feel well-prepared for employment.

Job-relevant skills

The competencies that graduates actually use on the job. According to Melchor et al. 2025) noted that core competencies in management, communication, and service were considered useful by both BSHM and BSTM graduates, while ICT and financial skills emerged as areas needing further improvement. Mari et al. (2023) assessed the curriculum's relevance across knowledge/technical, communication, human relations,

leadership, research, and ICT at Batangas State University, showing that the goal of hospitality programs is to give graduates a wide range of skills that enhance employability. (J. Punsalan et al. (2024) found that tourism graduates in General Santos City rated the cognitive, communication, leadership, interpersonal, and information technology skills they learned in college as "very helpful" in their current situation. They also suggested that more skills-based subjects, like tour guiding and travel promotions, and stronger on-the-job training should be added. Likewise, Pepito et al. (n.d.) indicated that hospitality graduates recognized operational skills such as food and beverage management, bartending, and housekeeping as essential competencies in their employment, in addition to communication and interpersonal skills, which they deemed the most significant soft skills. Magboo-Campo (2025) found that tourism management graduates still needed to strengthen their digital skills, even if the training was generally well-received. This highlights how crucial it is to have technical skills in tourism jobs. Supporting this, studies on employability skills in the hospitality sector report that employers place strong emphasis on generic attributes such as reliability, teamwork, communication, and problem-solving, which often determine hiring and promotion decisions as much as technical abilities Ghani et al. (2025) Research on personality types and multiple intelligences among hospitality and tourism management students likewise suggests that personal dispositions and cognitive strengths contribute to how effectively graduates apply their skills in the workplace Subia et al. (2022) Other work stresses the importance of critical thinking and financial management competencies in hospitality financial

management, arguing that these skills are necessary for graduates to manage increasingly complex business environments Maniram (2022) In international contexts, language communication competence has also been identified as a key factor influencing hospitality students' career adaptability and resilience in times of disruption such as the COVID-19 pandemic Ren et al. (2023) Overall, these studies support the idea that communication, leadership, service operations, and digital/ICT skills should be core abilities in CTHM curricula. Gevana and Tan (2021) found that, aside from tracer studies of employed alumni, students enrolled in hospitality programs consider problem-solving, communication, and interpersonal skills to be the most important employability skills needed for the industry. Their findings support the importance of developing soft skills; they remain critical skills for graduates entering the hospitality industry.

Employment Satisfaction

This captures how satisfied graduates are with their jobs in terms of pay, growth, and working conditions. The tracer study of hospitality management graduates from the University of Cebu by Pepito et al. (n.d.) reported that many graduates were satisfied with their salaries and wages and recognized the career challenges present in the hospitality industry. The study also noted that strong linkages between the college and hotel partners helped graduates secure employment within one year of finishing their degree, which likely contributed to their positive views of their work situation. Magboo-Campo (2025) observed that tourism management graduates expressed gratitude for the training and academic assistance provided by their university, but also pointed out that only a small

number had obtained international employment. This result suggests a generally positive perception of local job opportunities and support services, paired with an awareness of limitations in global career mobility. Although Abad et al. (2025) focused specifically on employment status, job satisfaction, and the relevance of academic preparation among BSHM graduates, the accessible abstract mainly underlines how tracer data can be used to assess these aspects and guide program improvement in hospitality management. Together, these tracer studies show that CTHM-related graduates are often satisfied with their jobs when they can apply their college training and when strong school–industry partnerships are in place, while also highlighting areas—such as international placement and advanced digital skills—where satisfaction and opportunities can still be improved.

Perceived Career Growth

Perceived career progression is the feeling that graduates have that they are moving up in their jobs through promotions, more responsibility, more pay, and chances to go up, no matter what their present work title or position is. Putra et al. (2022) analysed several longitudinal tracer studies of tourism and hospitality graduates in Indonesia and found that alumni generally viewed their careers as progressing when they could apply communication, problem-solving, and professional attitudes acquired in school to increasingly complex roles. Although many started in entry-level positions, graduates reported that strong soft skills and job-specific competencies improved their chances for promotion and lateral mobility in hotels, restaurants, and tourism enterprises, shaping their perceived career growth in the industry. A multi-year provider-based tracer study of

vocational education graduates in Albania revealed that tourism and hospitality graduates exhibited one of the highest employment rates (approximately 76–80%) among sectors, and reported relatively high levels of job security and job satisfaction, with around 70% characterizing themselves as satisfied or very satisfied with their work. Eventually, more graduates earning more than the minimum wage and claimed they wanted to established their own business. This shows that their thought tourism-related occupations would help them move forward in their careers while making more money over time. Recent research on tourism and hospitality students' career motivation further shows that career adaptability and career optimism significantly influence their intentions to remain in and progress within the industry, suggesting that psychological resources are an important part of perceived career growth Wang et al. (2024). Language competence and the ability to operate in multicultural environments have likewise been linked to better perceived career prospects and readiness to seize advancement opportunities in international hospitality contexts Ren et al. (2023)

Duldulao (2025) performed a tracer investigation of the BS Hospitality Management (BSHM) graduates of the University of La Salette, Inc., from the year 2019–2023, and revealed that the vast majority of the participants were working and believed that their jobs were in line with their degree. The authors observed that graduates' recognition of career development or growth was associated with promotion opportunities, professional development, and perceived alignment between academic preparation and sport work demands. Nonetheless, the authors recommended that further enhancement of the

curriculum might help graduates pursue positions in higher levels of responsibility, advancement, and longevity. Similarly, Diaz and Maramento (2023) conducted a study on the employability of Guimaras State College graduates in Hotel and Restaurant Management and Hospitality Management from 2017 to 2021. They discovered that the majority were employed in hospitality-related role. However, a large number of people who tool part said they were self-employed or worked for small enterprises. Graduates described that what they learned in college especially service operations and customer relations were beneficial skills that helped them gain and maintain employment. Several graduates described their current position as "a stepping stone" to a better job and salary. Participants generally had a positive outlook of future career development.

Job Search Pathways

The transition from higher education into employment is rarely a linear process, especially in service-dominant deployed contexts such as tourism and hospitality. Job search pathways represent the processes, methods, and channels graduates use to find work, along with the influence from both institutions and external labor market conditions shaping those pathways.

International tracer studies have demonstrated graduates in tourism and hospitality, through obtaining their first employment, used some combination of formal and informal mechanisms. For example, a tracer study conducted by Mehari et al. (2024) found in Ethiopia a great deal about graduates from the Tourism Training Institute (TTI), and their school to work transition. The authors described both how graduates found employment,

how long it took them to obtain their first employment, and whether the job was related to their training. Their findings indicated graduates used several job-search pathways, such as personal networks, responses to job postings, and connections made during the training.

In a broader vocational education context, Skills for Jobs (2023) undertook a national tracer study in Albania that examined what happens to students once they graduate from vocational education. The tracer study followed graduates' job search pathways into employment and emphasized the role of personal networks of the graduates significantly. Recent tracer studies conducted in the Philippines, specifically focusing on hospitality management, have produced similar trends and highlighted how the local labor market operates. For exampleMari et al. (2023) conducted a tracer study examining graduates from their Hospitality Management Program at Batangas State University JPLPC–Malvar Campus, traced in fiscal years 2021 and 2022. Their article revealed how graduates secured their first position by emphasizing the importance of on-the-job training (OJT), career fairs, professor referrals, and individual applications (walk-in/posting applications). As the results suggested, garnering policies from the institution, especially related to practicum placements and professional ties, greatly influenced the graduates' job searching strategies. In expanding the area of discussion toward internship experiences, (Matulin, n.d.) compared BSHRM graduates who had internship abroad versus local internship experiences. The study researched how graduates' experiences in internships influenced their job placement, career options, and opportunities. (Matulin, n.d.) argues

that graduates who interned overseas reported more favorable employment outcomes (comparing to graduates who interned domestically), successful employment overseas, or employment in their field of study. The researchers suggest that students' internship context influences the outcome of their job searching (locally or overseas) - and the quality of the job acquired. Babaran Jr. (2025) showed that a web-based alumni employability platform improves graduates' access to job opportunities and career resources while helping institutions track employment trends and enhance career services.

Employment Challenges

In addition to how graduates find jobs, it is equally important to consider the barriers to finding and maintaining meaningful employment. Employment challenges include job mismatch, precarious working conditions, underemployment, and skills mismatch between academic preparation and workforce expectations.

Within the global academic context, tourism and hospitality graduates are often recognized as fragile in turbulent labor markets employment markets. Stemele (2022) studied graduate employment within tourism and hospitality, examining the characteristics and challenges that influence graduates' minimal employment outcomes. The study indicated that despite having qualifications, the majority of the graduates faced problems including few jobs available, competition from individuals with more experience, and taking positions that were low wage or seasonal. (Stemele, 2022) raised further issues around the fit of the academic training, with skill-set expectations outlined

by employers, which affects the chances of graduates securing meaningful, sustainable employment.

In line with this thinking, Sufi (2024) framed the employability of tourism and hospitality graduates, with examples of practice, in the context of a VUCA (volatile, uncertain, complex and ambiguous) world. Sufi (2024) emphasized that rapid changes in technology, consumer preferences, and global disruption (such as health crises and world events) work together to create pressures or dilemmas for new graduates. The study highlighted the implications of weak partnership between industry and academia on graduates. At the firm level, research during the COVID-19 pandemic has shown that perceived job insecurity and pandemic-related stressors significantly increased turnover intention among hotel employees, further illustrating how external shocks create additional employment challenges for hospitality workers Yin et al. (2022)

Philippine studies present a similar picture of constrained opportunities and job mismatch in the hospitality and tourism sector.

(Diaz and Maramento, 2023) conducted a tracer study to analyze the employability of BS Hotel and Restaurant Management graduates of Guimaras State College for the years 2017-2021. The tracer research consisted of data regarding graduates' employment status and the nature of their work in relation to their degree. (Diaz and Maramento, 2023) shown that numerous graduates encountered HRM employment-related challenges when entering the workforce, compelling them to choose occupations unrelated to their

degree, hence underscoring the complexities of employability concerning job relevance and availability.

In a different state university setting, an employability tracer study was conducted by (Sabando et al. (2022) of the Bachelor of Science in Hotel and Restaurant Management graduates. In their study, they found that not every graduate gained employment, and of those attained jobs, many were only in entry-level or non-competencies related jobs.They also noted that some graduates experienced a waiting period before securing their first job due to the labor market and/or when they felt unprepared for employment. These local findings imply that, even in a country where tourism is a priority sector, hospitality graduates are still faced with a variety of obstacles to obtaining secure, meaningful employment.

Placement Service Satisfaction

Although employed outcomes are usually the primary focus in tracing studies, it is also important to investigate the level of satisfaction graduates feel with the institutions and placement services themselves as an important aspect of program effectiveness. Satisfaction with placement services is how graduates feel they have been supported by their institution in their job readiness in terms of career planning, job placement, and general preparedness to work in their field.

In Ethiopia, the Tourism Training Institute has undertaken several tracer studies that examine recent graduates' experiences with support through the institution. (Mehari et al. (2024) evaluated TTI's training courses in light of the employability of its graduates

from 2023. They not only evaluated employability data but also included measures of graduates' satisfaction with training and support in entering the workforce. Mehari et al. (2024) indicated that participants' perceptions about whether programs had relevance, the value of the services offered, and perceived exposure to any work-based experiences provided all reflected strong relationships with satisfaction about the institution's role in ensuring preparation for the job market. Earlier, Feredegn (2023) completed a tracer study of TTI's graduates from 2020-2022 and similarly investigated graduates' views on academic support and services from the institution. Feredegn (2023) stated that academic advising, co-op training, and institutional networking are all areas that are particularly beneficial in supporting graduates.

Their findings showed when graduates have a sense of strong institutional support, they are more likely to be satisfied following their transition to work. These findings imply that placement service satisfaction is a contributing factor to the assessment of placement factors for specific tourism and hospitality program placements. Internationally, systematic first-destination and graduate outcome reports also highlight how feedback from alumni on institutional support, career services, and transition-to-work experiences is used to refine employability strategies and enhance placement mechanisms over time Research Staff (n.d.)

Placement-related satisfaction in the Philippines is typically integrated into tracer studies that consider program quality and graduate feedback. Comicho and Apangchan-Laurel (2023) for example, investigated program quality and feedback from Hospitality

Management and Tourism Management graduates from 2015-2019 as part of a tracer study focused on generating inputs for curriculum and institutional improvement, program relevance, and the role of various support services related to graduate employability and their links with industry. Comicho and Apangchan-Laurel (2023)like other tracer studies, stressed the importance of graduating student input in terms of establishing which aspects of the program occupationally prepared graduates for employment, training relevance, support services, and linkages with industry.

Other researchers, like Sabando et al. (2022) documented graduates' employability for Bachelor of Science in Hospitality and Restaurant Management (BSHRM) graduates and reported on graduates' ratings for program strengths. Even though they did not call these "placement services," Sabando et al. (2022) suggested that graduates believed that some components of the service and support framework were advantages in regard to learning how to obtain a job after graduation. In both instances, the graduates mention how satisfied they are with the school's support, services, and job placement processes.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

This research study is based on two major theories: The Human Capital Theory and Employability Theory, both of which explain how graduates' characteristics, skills, and educational experiences influence their employment outcomes. the Human Capital Theory (Gary Becker and Theodore Schultz, 1964) both an individual and societies benefit from investing in education, training, and skill development. Individuals who invest in these areas are more productive and have more job

opportunities. In actuality, formal education provides people with the skills and information they need to find and keep decent employment, as well as earn more money over time. In this study, graduates' profiles (year of graduation, civil status, sex, and age) serve as predictors of employability outcomes. These attributes form part of the human capital that graduates bring to the workforce. Their academic background and personal characteristics shape their chances of securing relevant, stable employment in the tourism and hospitality industry.

Based on (Yorke & Knight, as cited in Bartleby, n.d.) explains that employability depends not only on academic knowledge but also on personal attributes, transferable skills, and contextual factors. Graduates need competencies such as communication, interpersonal, problem-solving, entrepreneurial, and critical thinking skills. These abilities help graduates succeed and adapt in tourism and hospitality workplaces. The theory also stresses that employability continues to develop, depending on individual action and how well the educational experience aligns with the needs of future employers. Together, the characteristics in graduates' profiles (independent variables) are linked to their levels of engagement and employment outcomes (dependent variables)

1.4 Schematic Diagram

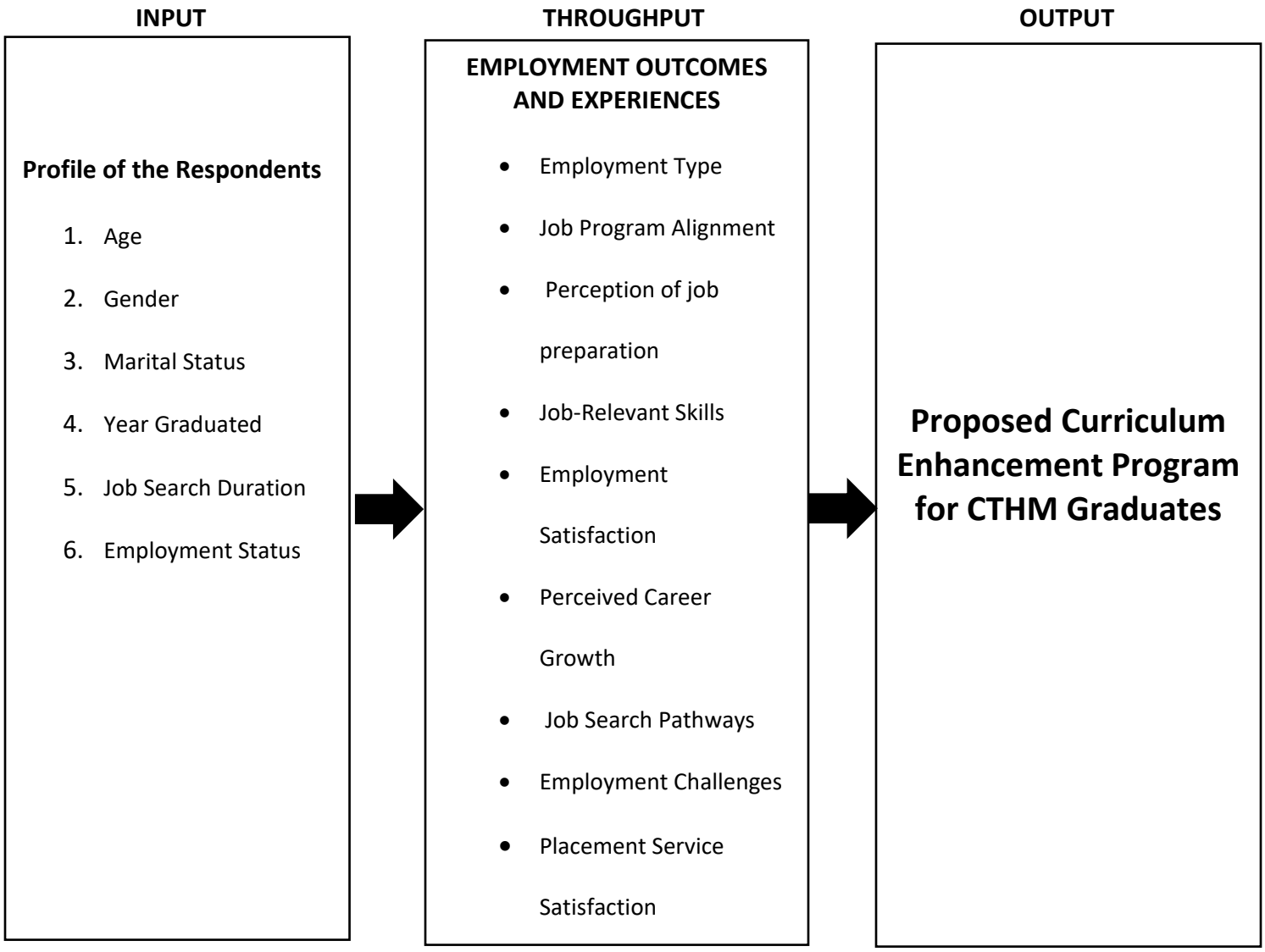


Figure 1. The Schematic Diagram presents the connection between the study variables.



1.5 Statement of the Problem

The study examines the satisfaction, career paths, and application of skills and knowledge gained from the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management at Saint Michael College of Caraga, focusing on graduates from the 2022–2023, 2023–2024, and 2024–2025 batches. It also investigates their demographics, employment characteristics, and the relevance of their degree to their current jobs.

1. What is the profile of the CTHM graduates in terms of:
   - 1.1 age;
   - 1.2 gender;
   - 1.3 marital status;
   - 1.4 year graduated;
   - 1.5 job search duration; and
   - 1.6 employment status?

2. What are the employment outcomes and experiences of CTHM graduates in terms of the following:
   - 2.1 employment type;
   - 2.2 job–program alignment;
   - 2.3 perception of job preparation;
   - 2.4 job-relevant skills;

2.5 employment satisfaction;

2.6 perceived career growth;

2.7 job search pathways;

2.8 employment challenges; and

2.9 placement service satisfaction?

3. Is there a significant relationship between the profile of CTHM graduates and their job-relevant skills, employment outcomes, and work experiences?

4. Based on the findings of the study, what curriculum enhancement program can be proposed for CTHM graduates that is responsive to their employment outcomes, employment experiences, and identified needs?

1.6 Hypothesis

There is no significant relationship between the respondents' profile and their job-relevant skills, employment outcomes, and work experiences.

1.7 Definition of Terms

The following terms are operationally defined as they pertain to the profiles, employment outcomes, and experiences of CTHM graduates.

Age. refers to the respondent's current age in completed years at the time of the survey.

Employment Challenges. refer to the difficulties and barriers experienced by graduates in finding a job or adjusting to their work, such as lack of experience, job mismatch, competition, or limited opportunities.

Employment-Satisfaction. refers to the level of contentment of graduates with their current employment, including their job role, work environment, salary, and benefits.

Employment Status. refers to the respondent's ability to express their thoughts verbally in a workplace.

Employment Type. In this study, employment type refers to the kind of work arrangement of the graduates, such as full-time, part-time, contractual, project-based, or freelance.

Gender. In this study, gender refers to how the graduates identify themselves (e.g., male, female, or other gender identity) as indicated in the survey.

Job Program Alignment. refers to the extent to which the graduates' current job is related or matched to the academic program they completed.

Job Search Duration. refers to the length of time (in months or years) it took for graduates to find their first job after graduation.

Job Search Pathways.refer to the methods and channels used by graduates to find employment, such as online applications, referrals, school placement services, walk-in applications, or social media.

Job-Relevant Skills. refer to the knowledge, technical skills, and soft skills that graduates gained from the program and use in their current job.

Marital Status. refers to the civil status of the graduates, such as single, married, separated, widowed, or in a registered partnership.

Perceived Career Growth. refers to graduates' views on their opportunities for promotion, professional development, and long-term advancement in their chosen career.

Perception of Job Preparation. refers to how graduates rate or feel about how well their academic program prepared them for the responsibilities and demands of their job.

Placement Service Satisfaction. refers to how satisfied graduates are with the school's assistance in job placement, such as career guidance, job fairs, referrals, and linkages with employers.

Sex. refers to the biological classification of the graduates as male or female, based on what is recorded at birth.

Year Graduated. refers to the specific year in which the graduates completed their academic program and were officially conferred their degree.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter will discuss the research design, research locale, research respondents, and research instrument that will be used in the study. It will also explain the ethical standards, data-gathering procedures, and statistical treatment that will be employed.

2.1 Research Design

The researchers will use a quantitative method, specifically a survey questionnaire, to determine the employment outcomes and experiences of graduates from the Saint Michael College of Caraga College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (SMCC-CTHM). The study will focus on CTHM graduates from the identified batches and will gather data on their profile (age, gender, marital status, year graduated, job search duration, and employment status), as well as on key employability indicators such as employment type, job–program alignment, perception of job preparation, job-relevant skills, employment satisfaction, perceived career growth, job search pathways, employment challenges, and placement service satisfaction. This quantitative approach, carried out through structured surveys, is appropriate because it allows the researchers to obtain measurable data from a larger number of graduates and to examine patterns and differences in employment outcomes when they are grouped according to their profile variables. The survey

questionnaire will be a researcher-modified instrument anchored on the tracer studies of Simangca et al. (2022) and Magboo-Campo (2025), and it will undergo reliability and validity testing to ensure that the items accurately capture the intended variables and yield consistent, dependable results for analysis.

2.2 Research Locale

The study will be conducted at Saint Michael College of Caraga, Brgy. 4 Atupan St., Nasipit, Agusan del Norte, specifically within the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM) department. In Nasipit, Agusan del Norte, education in Tourism and Hospitality has developed alongside the region's growing tourism industry. Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC) played a central role by offering specialized programs, such as the Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and the Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management, preparing students for careers in these vital sectors.

The College of Tourism and Hospitality Management at Saint Michael College of Caraga is one of the key departments, designed to meet the growing demand for professionals in the tourism and hospitality industries, especially within the region and globally. The department aimed to develop graduates who are competent in the dynamic and highly competitive sectors of tourism and hospitality.



2.3 Research Environment, population, and sample

The study focused on Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management graduates at Saint Michael College of Caraga in Brgy.4 Atupan St., Nasipit, Agusan del Norte. The study will involve CTHM graduates, and the researchers will use purposive sampling to select the study's respondents.

Table 1. Respondents of the study

School Year	Population				Sample					
	BSHM		BSTM		BSHM		BSTM			
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Total F	Percentage
S.Y. 2022-2023	17	35	9	26	11	23	6	17	57	34.8
S.Y. 2023-2024	19	27	1	15	13	18	1	10	42	25.6
S.Y. 2024-2025	24	23	5	47	16	15	3	31	65	39.6
TOTAL	**60**	**85**	**15**	**88**	**40**	**56**	**10**	**58**	**164**	**100.0**

Table 1 shows the distribution of respondents involved in the study. Specifically, Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management students at Saint Michael College of Caraga.

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

Research Instrument

The research instrument will be a researcher-modified survey questionnaire designed to collect data from graduates of the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM). The instrument will be adapted from the tracer studies of L. Simangca et al. (2022), titled "Tracer Study of Bachelor in Hotel and Restaurant Service Technology (BHRST) Graduates of Bohol Island State University Candijay Campus, Bohol, Philippines," and Magboo-Campo (2025), "Employability Pathways among Tourism Management Graduates: A Tracer Study." Guided by these works, the present study will adopt similar tracer-study structures and key variables, including the graduates' demographic profile, employment characteristics, and indicators of employability such as job-program alignment, perceived job preparation, job-relevant skills, employment satisfaction, perceived career growth, job search pathways, employment challenges, and placement service satisfaction. Using these concepts as a basis, a self-made instrument will be developed to fit the context of CTHM graduates at Saint Michael College of Caraga

The questionnaire will consist of three main parts based on the variables indicated in the schematic diagram. Part I will cover the graduates' profile, specifically age, gender, marital status, year graduated, job search duration, and employment status Part II will focus on employment outcomes and experience of the graduates, including employment type, job–program alignment, perception of job preparation, job-relevant skills, employment satisfaction, perceived career growth, job search pathways, employment challenges, and placement service satisfaction. Items in this section will use a four-point Likert scale to measure the respondents' level of agreement where 4 indicates Strongly Agree, 3 indicates Agree, 2 indicates Disagree, and one indicates Strongly Disagree. Part III will include an open-ended question that allows respondents to provide suggestions and recommendations for improving the CTHM curriculum. Their responses will serve as the basis for the development of a Proposed Curriculum Enhancement Program for CTHM Graduates.

The instrument will be submitted to the research adviser and other experts for content validation to ensure clarity, accuracy, and alignment with the study objectives before it is distributed to respondents for data collection.

Statistical Treatment

In presenting, analyzing, and interpreting data, the researcher used the following statistical test, namely.

Frequency and Percentage – This tool used to answer SOP 1, in determining the profile of the respondents.

Weighted Mean - This tool used to answer SOP 2 and 3, in determining the challenges and preparedness of college students for internship.

Pearson's r Correlation – It was used to answer SOP 4, in determining the relationship among the profile of the respondents, challenges and preparing for internship in area of preparedness.

Spearman rho Correlation – It was used to answer SOP 5, in determining the relationship between challenges in preparing for internship and the area of preparedness among college students.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Intellectual Property Right

This study respected intellectual property rights by keeping respondents' names private throughout the analysis. All secondary data and existing literature had been correctly cited, honoring the intellectual property of others while protecting the researcher's own contributions.

B. Informed Consent

The respondents will be informed of the graduates of the Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and the Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management programs from Saint Michael College of Caraga. The respondents underwent a brief orientation

conducted by the researchers to better understand the study's purpose and the potential benefits and risks before agreeing to participate.

The respondents will be informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any time without any explanation. During the orientation, a written consent form was distributed to each respondent to ensure they fully understood their rights.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The personal information gathered, including respondents' demographics, was kept entirely secret and only utilized after respondents completed a form giving their informed consent. To protect responders' identities, all records are anonymous. The researchers were responsible for distributing the surveys to ensure that the answers remained private. Researchers kept the key that linked identifying numbers to responders safe. During the survey, all data were kept safe and secure, preserved, and used solely for research, ensuring respondents' privacy was always protected.

D. Voluntary participation

Participation in the study was voluntary. Respondents in the survey were informed of their right to withdraw without any negative consequences. No animals were involved in this study; therefore, the consideration of alternatives to animal use was not applicable.

E. Minimization of Harm

To create a secure and supportive study environment, the researchers treated the respondents with respect and professionalism. If any hazards were identified,

respondents were referred to appropriate support services, such as the clinic and the Guidance Office, to ensure their safety and health throughout the research process. After participants finished, the researchers held a debriefing session to ensure no one was physically, mentally, or emotionally harmed during the study. The study did not include animal participants; thus, the 3Rs principles of replacement, reduction, and refinement were not relevant.

F. Beneficence

This study contributed to a better understanding of the challenges faced by CTHM students and their level of preparedness for upcoming internships. The study's findings were available upon request by the respondents. The study focused on improving the program and was based on its results.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

Respondents we will be selected using clear, fair inclusion criteria, ensuring that the selection process aligned with the study's goals. People from different backgrounds were included honestly and without bias.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Data collection and analysis will be conducted using standardized methods to ensure accurate and reliable results. Initially, the researchers submitted a formal request to the school registrar to obtain the complete list of eligible respondents for the study. All findings were carefully reviewed to avoid potential bias or error, and no limitations were identified in the study.

I. Transparency in Reporting

The study's findings will be reported honestly, with no manipulation or alteration of the data. All sources, including academic references, were cited correctly and acknowledged to ensure respect for intellectual property rights and uphold ethical research standards. This study utilized some AI tools to support various aspects of the research. There was no potential conflict of interest involved in the study.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

No patented materials were involved in this study. All copyrighted materials, including references, will be appropriately cited in accordance with intellectual property laws. The researchers ensured that all sources were appropriately acknowledged, maintaining academic integrity and avoiding plagiarism.

K. Considerations for Human Subjects

The researchers will inform respondents about the possible risks and potential benefits of the study and will ensure that an informed consent form is provided. If any significant risks are identified, such as emotional, physical, or psychological, appropriate health monitoring programs and emotional support services will be available.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related technology

The researchers used digital technologies throughout the research process, including finding reliable articles to maintain the study's accuracy and credibility. AI tools, such as

ChatGPT, were utilized to assist in summarizing statements and enhancing the quality of the study. Platforms such as Google Scholar, Elicit, and Typeset.io were used to identify supporting studies, thereby ensuring the research's reliability and credibility. Additionally, Grammarly was used to ensure the research report met proper grammar and clarity standards. The responsible use of technologies helped maintain the integrity of the study.

M. Ethical Approval

The research obtained ethical approval from the Institutional Review Board of Saint Michael College of Caraga, confirming its compliance with all relevant guidelines on the protection of respondents, data privacy, and intellectual property rights.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure

In gathering the data, the researchers sent a request letter to the school registrar, which was verified by the CTHM dean, to obtain the complete list of respondents for the study. This list was then forwarded to the statistician to ensure that the population remained consistent. After confirming this, the researchers crafted the research instrument and conducted a validity test to ensure its accuracy. Following this, the researchers performed pilot testing and submitted the results to the statistician to obtain a reliable research instrument for the study. Subsequently, the researchers sent an approval letter to the CTHM dean to seek permission to conduct the study. After securing approval, the researchers conducted the actual data gathering and distributed the survey questionnaire

to obtain the results. Once all data had been collected, the researchers tallied the results from the respondents' questionnaires and submitted the tabulated data to the statistician to ensure accuracy and reliability. After obtaining the tabulated data from the statistician, the researchers analyzed, interpreted, and discussed the information gathered.

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